

Is Malta seventh in the EU for cars per person?

Testing a media report of Eurostat's passenger-car figures against the data and its dates

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Malta is ranked number seven, just between Germany and Poland ... with 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants.”

Lovin Malta (J. Darmanin), 21 September 2024.

The outlet's own text, citing Eurostat; no year given for the figure.

VERDICT: MISLEADING

A 2022 rank presented as current; 2023 figures put Malta 12th

Version 1.0 (draft) · 6 October 2026

Status: pending right of reply (Lovin Malta)

Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

On 21 September 2024 Lovin Malta wrote that Eurostat had “shared a dataset ... as of 2023” on passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, and that “**according to the statistics Malta is ranked number seven, just between Germany and Poland respectively, with 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants.**” We tested the figure and the rank against Eurostat’s data, and against what Eurostat had published by the date of the article.

- 1

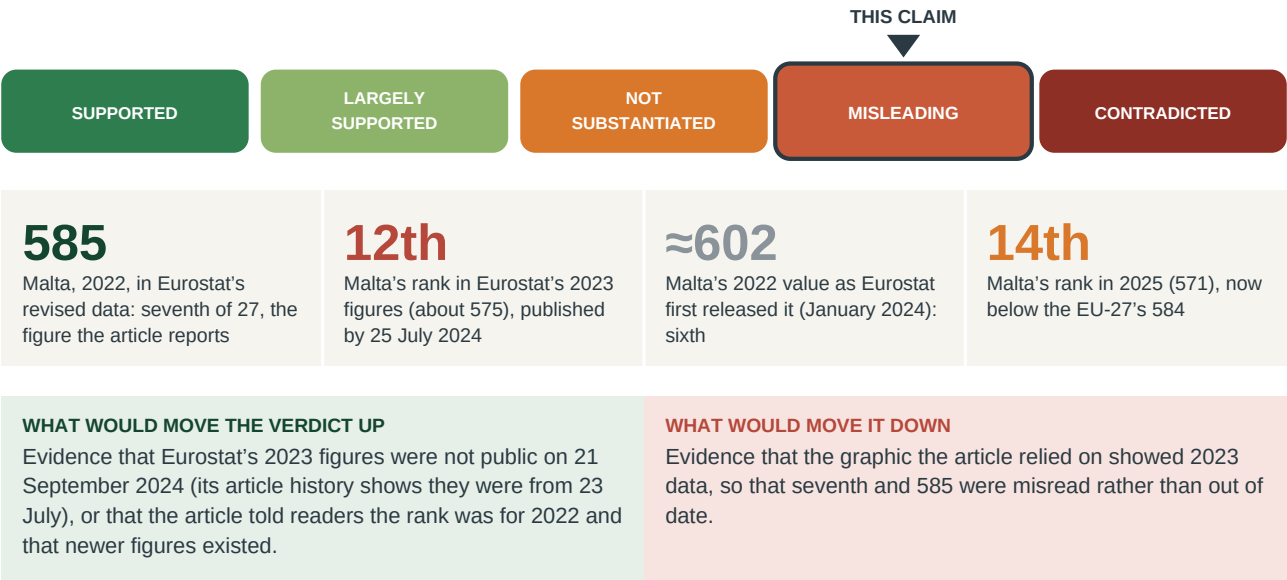
The figure is right for 2022, in revised data. Eurostat’s current data give Malta 585 in 2022, seventh of 27, between Germany (587) and Poland (584) [2]. Eurostat’s own release of January 2024 had Malta’s 2022 value at about 602, sixth [6, 14]; it was revised later.
- 2

Eurostat’s newer figures put Malta 12th. By 25 July 2024, about two months before the article, Eurostat had published 2023 figures for all 27 Member States: Malta about 575, 12th; EU 571. That version of Eurostat’s article was online on the day the article appeared [13].
- 3

The article presents the old rank as current. It calls Eurostat’s dataset “as of 2023” and says Malta “is ranked number seven”, while dating its graphic “up to the year 2022”. It never says the 585 is a 2022 figure, and does not mention the 2023 figures.
- 4

Lower since. In today’s revised data Malta is 11th for 2023 and 14th for 2025 (571, below the EU-27’s 584) [2]; its population has grown faster than its car stock [3, 4]. Side remarks: 585 per 1,000 is one car per 1.7 people, not per two; 246 km² is Malta island.
- 5

Verdict: misleading (high confidence). The 2022 figure is defensible, but leaving out that Eurostat’s latest figures put Malta 12th gives an inaccurate picture of where Malta stood.



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1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim is Lovin Malta’s own text, read in full on 6 October 2026 on the page and through the site’s WordPress interface (post dated 21 September 2024) [1]. Lovin Malta is a news outlet and is the speaker here; the sentences below are its words, not quotations of anyone else. The article names Eurostat as the source of the dataset and a graphic by Paula Lago via The European Correspondent as the source of the rankings. We could not find the graphic (section 10).

What Lovin Malta says	Where	Access
Eurostat “shared a dataset detailing the unit of cars per thousand residents in each European country as of 2023”; a graphic “better illustrated these rankings up to the year 2022”	Paragraphs 1–2 [1]	Read in full; graphic not found
“according to the statistics Malta is ranked number seven, just between Germany and Poland respectively, with 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants”	Paragraph 3 [1]	Read in full
Italy the “top-ranker ... at a whopping 682”; Latvia lowest “with only 409 per 1,000”	Paragraph 2 [1]	Read in full
“approximately 1 car for every 2 people”; “with just 246 square kilometres of land, Malta is also up there among the countries with the highest car density in Europe”	Paragraph 4 [1]	Read in full

The headline is “Malta Ranked Number Seven On Eurostat’s ‘Passenger Cars Per 1,000 Inhabitants’ Dataset”. The claim record’s summary (seventh in the EU, 585 per 1,000) matches the article; we rate the article’s own sentences, which add the neighbours (Germany, Poland), describe the dataset as “as of 2023” and give no year for the 585.

SCOPE NOTE

This check tests the statistics the article reports and how it presents them. It does not assess traffic, congestion, pollution or transport policy, which the article mentions in passing, nor the readers’ comments it summarises. Claim Check 003 covers Malta’s per-capita greenhouse gas emissions.

2 Method

Question. Was Malta seventh in the EU with 585 passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, between Germany and Poland; for which year; was that Malta’s latest rank when the article appeared; and are the article’s other figures right?

Evidence. This claim is statistical. On 6 October 2026 we downloaded through Eurostat’s API the rate (*road_eqs_carhab*, updated 30 July 2026) [2], the stock of passenger cars (*road_eqs_carmot*) [3], the population on 1 January (*demo_gind*) [4] and land area (*reg_area3*) [5], for every country and year, keeping Eurostat’s flags. The API serves only current data, so for what Eurostat had published before the article we used Eurostat’s own publications: its release of 17 January 2024 with its chart [6], and the revision history of its article “Passenger cars in the EU”, read through the site’s MediaWiki interface, with the charts each version showed [13, 14]. Eurostat’s charts were read by pixel measurement, calibrated on their gridlines and checked against the values Eurostat prints in the text (all within 1.2 cars per 1,000). Everything is recomputed by *tools/cc-075-report/* from *data/cc-075/* [12]. Crossref and OpenAlex were searched for peer-reviewed work on car ownership in Malta; one comparative study was read in full [9]. Malta’s National Statistics Office (NSO) and Transport Malta refused scripted access, so their figures are second-hand (♦) [10, 11].

Grades. Official statistics and reviews are grade C under our scale. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the indicator measures

Eurostat’s “motorisation rate” is the number of passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants [7]. A passenger car is a road motor vehicle designed to seat no more than nine people including the driver (category M1). Privately owned and company cars, taxis, private hire cars, shared cars and rented cars are included; light utility vehicles, buses and minibuses are not [7].

How the rate is built. We could not open Eurostat’s methodology page for this dataset (section 10), so we rebuilt the rate. Dividing each country’s car stock at 31 December [3] by its population on 1 January of the following year [4] reproduces Eurostat’s 2022 value for all 27 Member States, within one car per 1,000 [12]. For Malta: 317,234 cars at the end of 2022 and 542,051 people on 1 January 2023 give 585.2.

Registered or licensed? Eurostat collects these figures from national authorities through a questionnaire shared with the ITF and UNECE; collection methods are “not harmonised at EU level”, and vehicle registers “may include very old vehicles without signs of life” [7, 8]. For Malta, NSO publishes the stock of *licensed* motor vehicles. Its release for the end of 2022 is reported to give 424,904 licensed vehicles, 74.7% of them passenger cars, about 317,400 ♦ [10]; Eurostat’s 317,234 lies within the rounding range (317,191–317,616). NSO’s quarterly figures also count vehicles “taken off the road” (garaged, resold or scrapped) ♦ [11]. This suggests that Malta’s Eurostat figure is the licensed stock; we could not read NSO’s release to confirm it. Rented cars are in the numerator and residents only in the denominator [4, 7]; we found no readable count of rented cars in Malta’s stock.

4 What Eurostat had published by 21 September 2024

Eurostat released the 2022 figures on 17 January 2024. Its chart in that release, and the chart in its article “Passenger cars in the EU” at the time, put Malta sixth at about 602 [6, 14]. In July 2024 Eurostat updated the article with data extracted that month: from 23 July its text gives 2023 values (Italy 694, EU 571), and from 25 July its Figure 3 charts 2023 for all 27 Member States [13]. That version (revision 647912, saved 19 August 2024) stayed online until 5 November 2024, so it was Eurostat’s published picture on 21 September 2024 [13]. In it Malta is 12th, at about 575, behind France (about 578) and ahead of Austria (about 566) (Figure 1). The same version’s Table 2 gives Malta’s car stock as 317,234 for 2022 and 323,852 for 2023, the same as today’s data [3, 13].

Eurostat publication	Date	Year shown	Malta	Rank (EU-27)	Source
News release and chart; article Figure 3	16–17 Jan 2024	2022	about 602	6th	[6, 14]
Article “Passenger cars in the EU”, revision 647912 (live 19 Aug – 5 Nov 2024)	text 23 Jul, chart 25 Jul 2024	2023	about 575	12th	[13]
<i>Lovin Malta article</i>	21 Sep 2024	<i>not stated</i>	585	“number seven”	[1]
Database today (updated 30 Jul 2026)	—	2022 / 2023 / 2025	585 / 575 / 571	7th / 11th / 14th	[2]

“About” values are read from Eurostat’s charts by pixel measurement (data/cc-075/chart_reads.csv); they match every value Eurostat prints in the accompanying text within 1.2 cars per 1,000. Malta’s gap to its neighbours in the 2023 chart (about 3 and 8) is larger than that error.

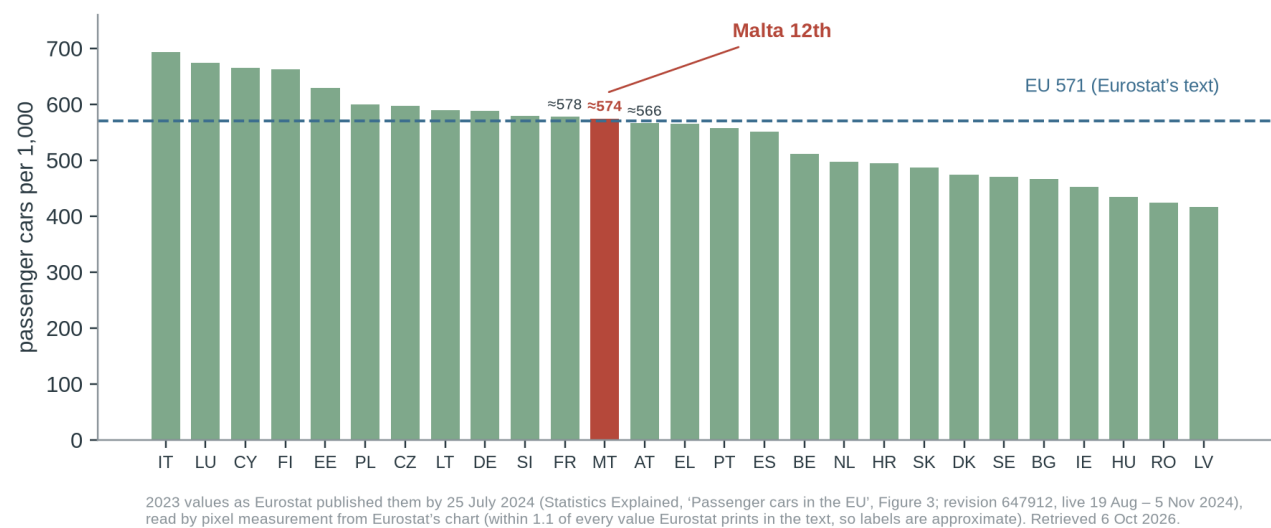


Figure 1. Passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants in 2023, as Eurostat published them by 25 July 2024 and as they stood on 21 September 2024. Malta is 12th [13].

So the article’s 585 and seventh place are the 2022 column of data revised after January 2024: the 2022 value Eurostat first released was about 602 (sixth), and when the article appeared Eurostat’s published 2023 figures put Malta 12th. The article does not say which year its figures are for.

5

What the data show now

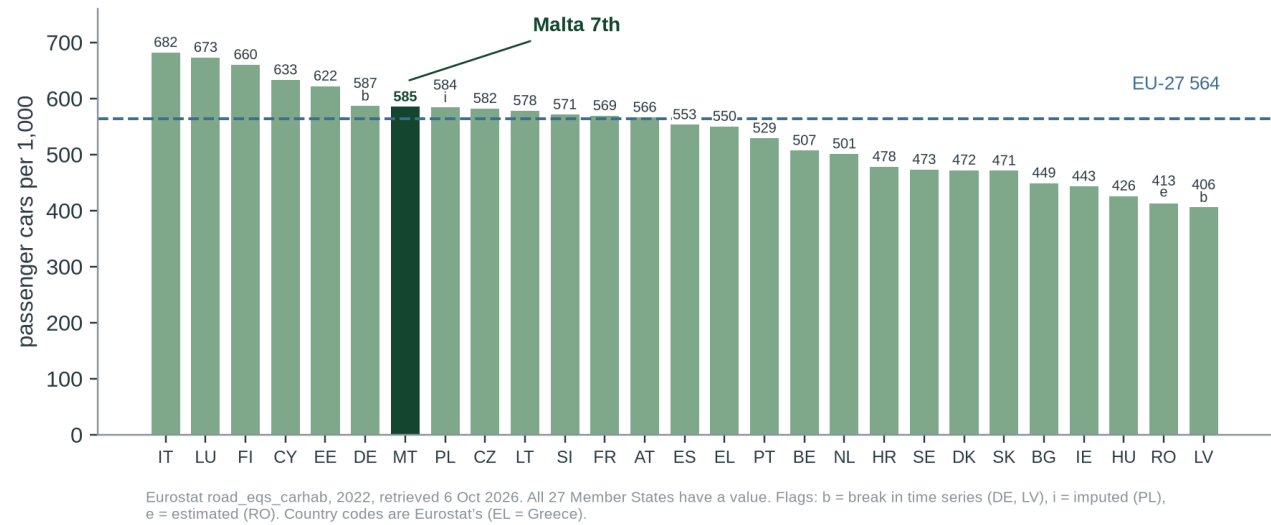


Figure 2. Passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, 2022, all 27 Member States, in today's data. Malta (585) is seventh, between Germany (587, break in series) and Poland (584, imputed); Czechia (582) is three cars behind. In Eurostat's January 2024 release Malta was sixth (about 602) and Poland about 571 [2, 6].

Indicator	Malta	Comparison	Source	Grade
Passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, 2022 (today's data)	585 (no flag)	EU-27 564	Eurostat [2]	C
Rank among the EU-27, 2022 (today's data)	7th of 27	Germany 587 (b), Poland 584 (i)	Eurostat [2]	C
Rank among all 41 countries in the dataset, 2022	9th	Liechtenstein 773, Iceland 611 (i) higher	Eurostat [2]	C
Rank, 2024 / 2025 (today's data)	13th / 14th	Malta 576 / 571; EU-27 577 / 584	Eurostat [2]	C
Car stock at 31 Dec 2022 vs NSO licensed passenger cars	317,234	about 317,400 ♦	Eurostat [3]; NSO [10]	C

Flags: b = break in time series, i = imputed. All values in data/cc-075/checks.csv [12]. Malta's values carry no flag in any year. Earlier published versions: section 4.

Malta's rank over time

In today's data Malta's rate rose from 302 in 1990 to a peak of 616 in 2016, and has drifted down since. Its rank in the EU-27 was third in eleven years (1995, 1997, 2007–2012 and 2014–2016), seventh in 2022 and 14th in 2025, when it fell 13 cars per 1,000 below the EU-27 value (Figure 3) [2]. A 2010 comparative study of four island states described Malta's car ownership as then “the highest in the European Union” [9]; it used a different measure and earlier data, and in Eurostat's current series Malta was third in those years.

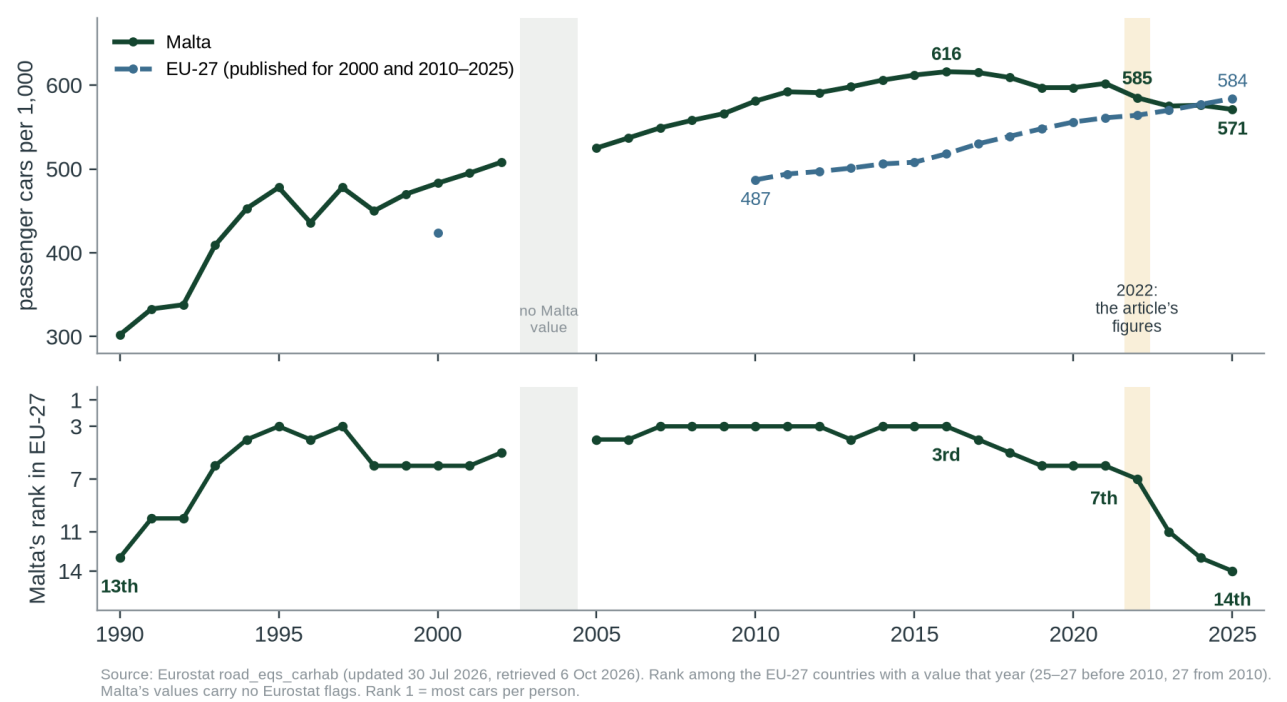


Figure 3. Top: passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, Malta and EU-27, 1990–2025, in today's data. Bottom: Malta's rank among the EU-27 countries with a value each year. The shaded band marks 2022, the year the article's figures match. No Malta value for 2003–2004 [2].

6

Population growth and car density

The fall in the rate is a population effect. Malta’s passenger car stock grew every year from 2006 to 2025 [3]: by 6,618 in 2023, 6,632 in 2024 and 5,209 in 2025. Its population grew faster: from the end of 2012 to the end of 2025 the car stock rose 34.5% (249,612 to 335,693) and the population 39.6% (421,464 to 588,254) [3, 4]. In 2022 alone the stock rose 1.3% and the population 4.2%, which is why the rate dropped from 602 to 585 in today’s data; from 2022 to 2025 the population grew 8.5% and the car stock 5.8% [3, 4].

Measured per km² of land instead of per person, Malta is far ahead of every other Member State: 1,014 passenger cars per km² in 2022 against 261 in the Netherlands, the next highest, and 1,073 in 2025 [3, 5]. The article’s 246 km² is Malta island (245 km² of land in Eurostat’s data); the whole country, including Gozo and Comino, has 313 km² [5]. The article’s sentence (Malta “up there among the countries with the highest car density”) holds on either area.

7

Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Was “seventh” Malta’s standing when the article appeared?

NO: 2023 FIGURES PUT MALTA 12TH

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM’S IMPRESSION

585 and seventh place are right for 2022 in Eurostat’s revised data [2], and the article dates its graphic “up to the year 2022”.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

Eurostat’s article, in the version online from 19 August to 5 November 2024, gave 2023 figures for all 27 Member States, with Malta 12th at about 575 [13]. The Lovin Malta article calls the dataset “as of 2023”, states the rank in the present tense and never gives a year for the 585.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the 2022 figure is defensible, but presenting seventh as Malta’s standing, without saying it was 2022 or that Eurostat’s newer figures put Malta 12th, leaves out a material fact and gives an inaccurate picture.

Comparability. Eurostat publishes and ranks these rates side by side [6, 7], and Malta’s values carry no flag, but collection methods are “not harmonised at EU level” and registers may hold cars with no “signs of life” [7]. Revisions also move places: after January 2024 Malta’s 2022 value went from about 602 to 585 and Poland’s from about 571 to 584 [2, 6]. Places 6 to 9 in 2022 are within five cars per 1,000 (Germany 587, Malta 585, Poland 584, Czechia 582). Exact positions are fragile, a further reason to give the year and the version of the data with a rank.

8

Testing the claim

Each statement in the article, rated on its own; the verdict (section 9) weighs them together.

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Malta has 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants	Right for 2022 in data revised after January 2024: 585, no flag; rebuilt from 317,234 cars and 542,051 people [2–4]. Eurostat’s January 2024 release had about 602 [6].	ACCURATE (2022, REVISED DATA)
B. Ranked number seven, between Germany and Poland	Seventh of 27 for 2022 in today’s data, between Germany 587 (b) and Poland 584 (i) [2]. In the January 2024 release Malta was sixth and Poland 11th [6].	ACCURATE (2022, REVISED DATA)
C. Presented as current: dataset “as of 2023”, Malta “is ranked” seventh	The article dates its graphic “up to the year 2022” but calls the dataset “as of 2023” and gives the rank in the present tense. Eurostat had published 2023 figures by 25 Jul 2024: Malta about 575, 12th [13]. Separately, in today’s revised data Malta is 11th for 2023 [2].	OUT OF DATE WHEN PUBLISHED

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
D. Italy top at 682, Latvia lowest at 409	Italy 682 matches today's 2022 data (684 in January 2024); Latvia is lowest in every version (406 now, 414 then) [2, 6].	LARGELY ACCURATE
E. "Approximately 1 car for every 2 people"	585 per 1,000 is one car for every 1.71 people [2]; the rounding understates the rate.	LOOSELY WORDED
F. 246 km² of land; among the highest car density in Europe	246 km² is Malta island; the country has 313 km² of land [5]. With 1,014 cars per km² of land Malta is first in the EU, 3.9 times the Netherlands [3, 5].	LARGELY ACCURATE

The figure and rank (A, B) reproduce from Eurostat’s data for 2022, but only from the version revised after January 2024. How they are presented (C) is the problem: the article reports them as Malta’s current standing when Eurostat’s published 2023 figures put Malta 12th. The side remarks (D–F) are right in direction: Latvia’s figure differs by data version, “1 car for every 2 people” understates Malta’s rate, and 246 km² is the main island, though Malta leads the EU on car density on either area.

9

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

MISLEADING

The 2022 figure is right in revised data, but the article presents seventh as current when Eurostat’s 2023 figures, published two months earlier, put Malta 12th. Confidence: high.

Why. (1) Malta’s 585 and seventh place, between Germany and Poland, match Eurostat’s 2022 data as revised after January 2024; Eurostat’s January 2024 release had Malta sixth at about 602 [2, 6]. (2) By 23–25 July 2024 Eurostat had published 2023 figures for all 27 Member States, and the version of its article that showed them was online from 19 August to 5 November 2024: Malta about 575, 12th [13]. (3) The article calls the dataset “as of 2023” and says “Malta is ranked number seven” without giving a year or mentioning the 2023 figures. Readers would take seventh as Malta’s latest standing; on Eurostat’s published figures it was not. Individual statements are defensible, but the omission makes the overall impression inaccurate, which is the scale’s definition of Misleading. (4) Confidence is high because Eurostat’s dated revision history, the chart file with its upload time and checksum, the values in Eurostat’s text and our pixel reading all agree [12, 13]. The documents are listed in the claim record (evidence shown).

What this verdict does not say. It does not say the 585 figure is wrong (it is right for 2022 in today’s data), and it says nothing about intent: the graphic the article used may itself have been built from 2022 data. It assesses the article as published. It also says nothing about congestion, pollution or transport policy.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From Lovin Malta: the graphic it used (Paula Lago, The European Correspondent), the data year and Eurostat release behind the 585 and the seventh place, and whether the article was checked against Eurostat’s 2023 figures.
- ☐ From NSO or Transport Malta: the stock of licensed passenger cars by year, the number of rented cars in it, and the number of registered but unlicensed (garaged) cars.

Right of reply. Under the project’s rule a reply is sought for a Misleading verdict. A letter to Lovin Malta has been drafted for the maintainer; any response will be appended and the verdict revisited. Until the reply deadline has passed, this draft verdict is shown only on Mizien’s own site.

10

Limitations

- Eurostat’s database serves only current data. What Eurostat had published earlier is shown through its Statistics Explained revisions and charts [13, 14] and its January 2024 release [6], not through a copy of the database itself. The article’s own data date is unknown.
- The earlier values are read from Eurostat’s charts by pixel measurement; they match every value Eurostat prints within 1.2 cars per 1,000, and Malta’s 12th place in 2023 rests on gaps of about 3 and 8.
- The graphic the article used (Paula Lago, The European Correspondent) was not found (the embedded Instagram post needs a login; web.archive.org reset every connection). Eurostat’s methodology page for road equipment returned “not found”, so the denominator was established by recomputation.
- NSO and Transport Malta refused scripted access. The licensed-vehicle figures [10, 11] are second-hand (♠); Newsbook’s passenger-car counts are internally inconsistent and are not used. No readable count of rented cars in Malta’s stock was found.
- Warren and Enoch [9] is a comparative study with data from the 2000s and a different measure; it is context only.

References

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- [2] Eurostat. road_eqs_carhab Passenger cars – per thousand inhabitants; updated 30 Jul 2026, retrieved 6 Oct 2026, with flags. doi:10.2908/ROAD_EQS_CARHAB. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/road_eqs_carhab/default/table?lang=en
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- [12] Miżien. Data and calculations: data/cc-075/; tools/cc-075-report/ (calc.py, read_charts.py).
- [13] Eurostat. Passenger cars in the EU. Statistics Explained, revision 647912 (saved 19 Aug 2024, replaced 5 Nov 2024; “Data extracted in July 2024”), with Figure 3 “Motorisation rate, 2023” (file uploaded 25 Jul 2024, sha1 7dd8b8d6...) and Table 2. Read through the MediaWiki API, 6 Oct 2026. <https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/api.php?action=query&prop=revisions&revids=647912&rvprop=content|timestamp&rvslots=main&format=json>
- [14] Eurostat. Passenger cars in the EU. Statistics Explained, revision 627098 (31 Jan 2024; “Data extracted in December 2023”), with Figure 3 “Motorisation rate, 2022” (file uploaded 16 Jan 2024, sha1 2eb4c04f...). Read through the MediaWiki API, 6 Oct 2026. <https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/api.php?action=query&prop=revisions&revids=627098&rvprop=content|timestamp&rvslots=main&format=json>

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	6 Oct 2026	First issue. Draft verdict Misleading (high confidence); pending right of reply (Lovin Malta).